

limitations. Since each bow is handmade, quality can be inconsistent. The limbs can crack in cold weather, and bowstrings occasionally snap mid-competition. At the National Games, a Manipur archer, Robinson Elangbom, saw his bowstring break during the team event, causing his team — the pre-tournament favourite — to crash out in the second round.

The bow's power is also significantly lower than a modern recurve. Indian bow competitions are held at a 50-metre distance, compared to the 70-metre standard in recurve events. "A recurve bow typically has a draw weight (the force required to pull the string) between 35 and 45 pounds. I have no idea what the draw weight of an Indian bow is, but it must be at least half of that," says four-time Olympian Deepika Kumari. The lightweight bamboo arrows, averaging just nine grams compared to the 30-gram Olympic-standard arrows, are highly susceptible to wind drift.

High margin for error

All these factors make the Indian bow, despite being a beginner's weapon, incredibly challenging to master. "It's much harder to shoot than a recurve bow," says Deepika. "A recurve bow is more powerful, and wind conditions don't affect it as much. The Indian bow's arrows are so light that their trajectory is much more curved, and even the slightest breeze impacts them. Indian bow *ke saath arrow daudta hai hawa ke saath!* (The Indian bow's arrow runs with the wind!)."

The handmade nature of the arrows also adds unpredictability. "One arrow might be lighter than the next, or slightly less straight. Once, while shooting, one arrow went to the top corner, another hit the centre, and a third landed at the bottom. On one occasion, my arrow drifted so much in the wind that it knocked someone's laundry off a clothesline! If anything you have to be very smart when you are shooting the Indian bow. You have to be very conscious of the arrow you are using and the wind that's blowing," she

recalls.

Unsurprisingly, most young archers can't wait to move on. "It's incredibly difficult to master, and you can't compete beyond the national championships with an Indian bow. If you want to participate in World Cups, the Asian Games, or the Olympics, you have to switch to recurve or compound," she explains.

Quick transition for most

Indeed, nearly every medallist in the Indian bow event aims to upgrade to a recurve bow as soon as possible. At the National Games, Deepika signed an application form for Jharkhand's 14-year-old Madho Birua — the youngest archery medallist at the event— to receive his first recurve bow. "I won't shoot the Indian bow anymore. I want to compete at the Olympics, and for that, I need to shoot recurve," he says.

Most talented archers transition out of the Indian bow category in their teens. Manipur coach Bijendranath Singh considers himself unlucky for being forced to stick with it. Despite being a multiple-time national champion and a silver medallist at the 2015 National Games, his job with Assam Rifles prevented him from switching. "I won my first national championship in 2008, then got a job with Assam Rifles. I kept winning, so they didn't want me to switch to recurve. I even won a gold at the national games in 2015. I finally left Assam Rifles in 2019, but by then, it was too late for me to start over," he laments.

Few choose to stay with the Indian bow out of preference. One such exception is Ravi, who is among the older archers in this category.

"I started with the Indian bow before switching to recurve at 17. I shot recurve for five years but wanted to compete at the National Games. I knew recurve competition would be much tougher, so I returned to the Indian bow. Now that I've won gold, I'll probably switch back," he says.

For most, however, the Indian bow is a mere stepping stone — one they are eager to leave behind.



Indian bow team gold medallist Ravi Malik of Haryana, who won men's team gold, appreciates its all-wood construction. "It's like the bow that Ram and Lakshman, and the warriors of the Mahabharata, used. This is part of our culture," says the 25-year-old, who has a sticker reading 'Jai Shri Shyam' on his bow's grip.